

Figure 5: Applying permissions

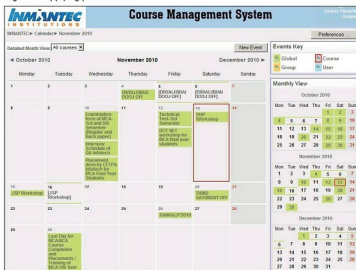


Figure 6: Calendar module



Figure 7: Cartoon

Sharing data and content with students

This problem was solved by using the course home-page feature of Moodle (http://docs.moodle.org/en/Course_homepage). Here, we place all our material, and students can easily access it after logging into the system and viewing a course home-page. The course home-page can be accessed only by those students who have enrolled in the course.

Publishing official documents

The syllabus, lesson plans, rule books and other official documents used to be handed to students in the form of a booklet or some other printed form, which was a waste of paper. We easily solved this problem by using Moodle's front-page feature (http://docs.moodle.org/en/Front_page). All resources like the time-table, rules, academic calendar, almanac (describing the activities for a session), and other documents, are displayed in the middle section of the front page. In Figure 2, you can see this as "TIME TABLE/ALMANAC/RULES-PGDM". These resources can be accessed by all users, and even guests.

Faculty-only areas

We wanted some sections of Moodle to only be accessed by faculty members. As you can see in Figure 2, the notice board forum for the HR department needed to be accessible only to faculty members and not to students. This function was enabled with roles and permissions (http://docs.moodle.org/en/Override_permissions) for individual notice boards.

Catering to users who aren't tech-savvy

Not every student is tech-savvy, and there are some students and staff who are not able to learn the technology. We cannot deprive them of information, yet we still have to keep things secure. So we got the guest login feature in Moodle activated. We also changed the permissions set for those Moodle components that are to be hidden from guest users, and those to be visible to guest users. Figure 5 shows us the permissions. We can also change or amend permissions, as required, in the future.

New content/upcoming events

Moodle users, on logging in to the site, must be able to find upcoming events and new or updated content on notice boards, at a glance. For this, we use the calendar module in Moodle. Figure 2 displays Upcoming Events, a component of Moodle. Figure 6 displays the calendar module.

Moodle is superb!

Moodle is, indeed, great software. If you are an academican who has faced the problems we did, this software will solve most of your issues, as outlined above. It works well with most databases and operating systems. I have personally tried it on Ubuntu 10.04, Windows 2003, and Win XP; believe me, it is fairly simple to get it working. We also customised the Moodle theme for our site (<http://cms.inmantec.edu>), so as to be in sync with Inmantec's website at <http://inmantec.edu>. There are also many books, videos and documentation on the Web about Moodle.

I hope you found my article of some use. I would like to receive your comments, suggestions or queries on the subject. 

Web references

- [1] Moodle site: <http://moodle.org>
- [2] Moodle documentation: <http://docs.moodle.org>
- [3] Moodle book: http://docs.moodle.org/en/Using_Moodle_book
- [4] Inmantec Moodle site: <http://cms.inmantec.edu>
- [5] Inmantec Google Apps site: <http://mail.inmantec-cms.org>
- [6] XAMPP: <http://apachefriends/en/xampp>

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